

Paper 5: Authority and the Family

Part of the difficulty in connecting this piece from Erich Fromm's "Sociopsychological Dimensions" with fascist theories is that the text is primarily concerned with explicating and deconstructing Freudian psychoanalysis. There is no shortage, however, of descriptive fascist critique as well as anti-fascist writings once we consider the intertwined significance of the super ego and authority. Indeed, what lies at the heart of this text is ultimately a cautionary tale with highly prophetic implications detailing the ways in which fascist and fascist-adjacent movements penetrate the psyche and subvert societal expectations. It is a psychoanalytical breakdown of the internal mechanisms which authoritarian movements rely on not only to survive, but to thrive. Finally, it reveals some interesting truths to the cultural politics of contemporary fascist-adjacent movements that were previously unheard of without a psychological perspective.

A simple yet often understated fact of authority in general and by proxy authoritarian movements is that they cannot be one-hundred percent constituted by coercion and fear. There is not a single authority figure in history who has managed to do so and the ones that tried failed early on. The reason for this, Fromm writes, is that submission based only on "real coercion" would require an apparatus that is unsustainable in the long run. "The quality of the work done by those acting only out of external fear would be paralyzed in a way that is at the very least incompatible with production" (pg. 15). Furthermore, it would effectively require the slowdown of all these productive forces in society in order to compensate for the instability and social

unrest. If we take this in historical terms, it makes complete sense that fascism in its archaic and palingenetic forms certainly relies to an extent on people's willingness to participate.

Fromm explains this willingness through a complicated redux of the Oedipus complex, one that I will attempt to explain to the best of my abilities. What's happening here isn't simply a rehash of the son's murderous fixation toward his father. Instead, Fromm paints a picture that follows the three stages of economic bonds in the family, and this forms the basis for the "crucial emotional nuance in the father-son relationship" (pg. 20). In agrarian societies, children were typically treated as another mouth to feed until they were old enough to join their brothers and sisters at work. Total fertility rates were high to balance high infant mortality. Children were viewed as a form of labor power so it made sense to have as many children as possible. When a society developed enough economically (think post-Industrial Revolution), this dynamic flipped and children were regarded as objects of "self-gratification". People actually wanted to start families and the antagonism that coded the previous epoch eventually gave way. However, the third and final stage of this development is what Fromm hones his focus to, and that is the petty bourgeois urban family. This version blends both harmony and hostility from the previous two family examples and creates the prototype for the type of authority he is writing about. Here, the father is the primary breadwinner of the family and is socially dissatisfied at a baseline. Like the previous example, he places his ambitions in his son and is thus a domineering yet simultaneously a supportive force in his son's life.

Ultimately, this fusion of psychological forces means a confusing array of projections on the son's part. While he certainly feels deference for this authority figure, and Fromm elaborates that credence is often given overgenerously, there is something more destructive at play. In a society colored by religious suppression and sexual repression, Fromm makes the argument that

the line separating stimulation and prohibition is thinner than we imagine. Pleasure in submission happens more often than not and masochistic tendencies tend to go hand in hand with sadistic cruelty. Thinking to the current moment, American Evangelical Protestants as a group are perhaps the most guilty, not only of pushing the fascist line but of parroting the same sadomasochistic drive that Fromm is writing on; a “life determined by powers that lie outside the individual” (pg. 45), repressed hatred of the authority that manifests as “hatred toward the gods of other religions and leaders of foreign peoples” (pg. 42).

The final connection which stood out to me should come as no surprise as Donald Trump embodies Fromm’s authoritarian ethos in more ways than one. A man who for the majority of his life was rejected by the conservative establishment, who literally had to build his own media empire and franchise because he was not welcome among the preexisting old money groups, suddenly finding himself the center of politics for well over a decade now. He is the billionaire of and for the people. He resonates perfectly with Fromm’s image of personified hatred for finance capital yet a concurrent worship for productive, self-made stardom; “rebellion against a father coupled with extreme obedience and submission to a leader” (pg. 42). His own contempt for the weak manifesting in plain misogyny and megalomania can only be matched by his eagerness for praise and applause. In his recent interactions with NYC Mayor Zohran Mamdani, what is seemingly viewed as uncharacteristic friendliness may in fact be what Fromm is getting at with the oscillation between love and hatred – wanting to associate oneself with the strong, with someone who knows how to win.